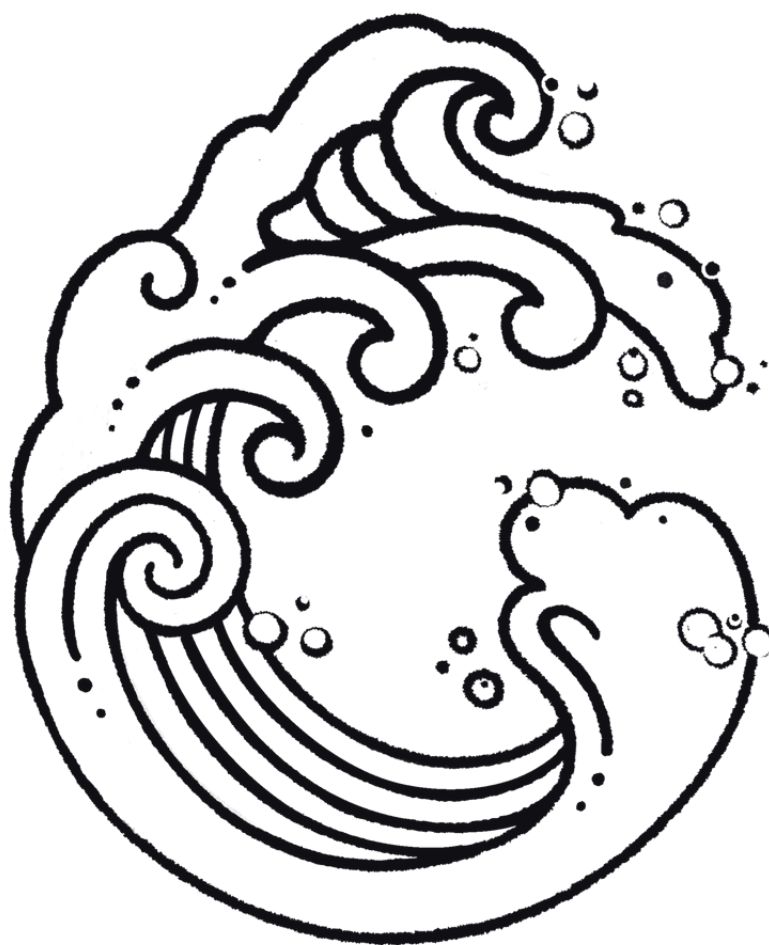




barróg

Vol I, Issue II:
Technology

Featuring Laura Sheeran,
State Magazine & more



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barróg

Barróg is a volunteer-based digital magazine highlighting Irish culture, and documenting the art that reflects it.

Thus this publication is entirely self-funded and claims no special rights or privileges.

For queries, submissions, and complaints, find us on social media:

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FROM THE EDITORS

As the summer draws to a close, we are very excited to share the second issue of *Barróg*. This issue was a big step up from our first issue, as we took public submissions for the first time and ended up almost doubling our page count from last time. We are also happy to have expanded the mediums present here, taking more creative writing and artwork than in our previous issue.

For this issue, we are diving into a technological and digital world to examine how technology can help and hinder art production. We ourselves are a digital magazine, and benefit immensely from the low costs associated with running this type of publication. We connect with our readers and contributors on social media, share our magazine on the internet, and can see that much of the Irish creative community is bolstered by an online presence. However, technology can also be seen to have a negative impact on the creation of artwork, and existing in online spaces is far from free of engaging with commercial incentives. Advertisers, algorithms and artificial intelligence have rendered the internet a precarious space for artists to exist within. It is with these conflicting ideas in mind that we set this issue topic.

A couple of key themes can be seen to emerge throughout the pieces you will read in this issue. Perhaps unsurprisingly, artificial intelligence is brought up again and again as an area of key concern. **Anya Wilson** discusses how AI makes it easier for online companies

like Shein to steal art; Rory O'Mahony's poetry tracks the process of relinquishing freewill to a chatbot; **Ella O'Neill** interviews Nathan Costello about his AI storytelling robot; **Laura Sheeran** addresses the uneven gendered dynamics that can be seen to emerge when engaging with artificial intelligence; our featured artist **Chantal Muriuki** transforms herself into a human AI chatbot, generating images based on prompts from her followers.

The surveillance that technology allows is also a common theme; the protagonist of **Pierce Woodall's** short story is followed through every second of her day, and in **Lasairíona Scarff's** "Everywhere You Look", digital monitoring is portrayed through non-technological mediums, striking a stark contrast.

In his poemt "Imeacht" **Daniel Wade** employs the use of some ancient technology as he reimagines Domhnall Cam Ó Súileabháin Bhéara's 17th-century march across Ireland. In the first article you will read, **Steven Dunne** details how the decision to make a website in 2008 would save the future of State.ie.

Technology has always transformed the way we make and engage with art, and while recent technological advancements may feel especially threatening to today's artists, we hope the work exhibited within these pages will give you confidence in the present and future of Irish art.

Lots of love,
Michaela and Ella

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state.

FACES OF 2014



featuring 20 new Irish artists including

Hozier

ALTERED STATE

A REFLECTION ON THE IRISH ARTS SCENE AND THE INTERNET

WRITTEN BY STEVEN DUNNE

PHOTOGRAPH VIA STATE MAGAZINE

The Irish music scene at this point in time can be viewed through any number of lenses. Essentially you can pick any story you wish to tell about an Irish musical entity and there is a cautionary tale, a heroic fable or even a beginners guide to bring your audience to precisely where you wish to drop them off. The same stories can be, and very usually are, told a hundred ways. This is because we share a country so small it generally means connections are real – really real. That is to say we all know somebody; that is the point. Everyone has a Bono story and everyone else remembers Sinéad, Dolores and Glen from ages ago. And in Ireland we absolutely love telling these stories.

Essentially you can pick any story you wish to tell about an Irish musical entity and there is a cautionary tale, a heroic fable or even a beginners guide to bring your audience to precisely where you wish to drop them off.

So, in 2006, *Hot Press* alumni Phil Udell, John Walsh and Roger Woolman all found themselves stood backstage shooting the breeze at the the

now defunct *Oxegen* festival. Their shared love of telling really real stories, combined with a significant knowledge of the Irish music scene and connections to the people propping it up, was the impetus for the creation of a new outlet. With financial backing from Woolman, *State Magazine* was about to be brought to life.

Over the coming months *State's* founders put together a team full of staggering talent. Award winning graphic designer Simon Roche, influential blogger (but hitherto relatively unknown) Niall Byrne (Nialler9), incredible writers including Cara Manning and Dave Hanratty who have both gone on to work at *Rolling Stone* and the *Irish Independent* respectively. As Phil Udell recounts, *State* wasn't just a shot in the dark. They had everything they needed to be part of the conversation around the likes of *Q*, *Uncut* and their former pals at *Hot Press*. Perhaps more importantly they had the talent to stay there. The initial plan was to launch the magazine for September 2007 and have an established presence for Christmas; which traditionally brings a windfall for publications of the sort. They found offices, sourced partners and distributors and had everything lined up. But alas and alack, fate

interposed as it always does.

Ostensibly, money everywhere evaporated and the Celtic Tiger which had sustained the burgeoning Irish indie scene was no more. To the mind of the founders, and in reality, this was fatal.

For myriad reasons the launch was delayed until spring 2008 which coincided with one of the most catastrophic global financial collapses of the modern era. Ostensibly, money everywhere evaporated and the Celtic Tiger which had sustained the burgeoning Irish indie scene was no more. To the mind of the founders, and in reality, this was fatal. The magazine persevered and stayed true to their ideals of producing a quality magazine with the highest grade features they could muster. It's pertinent at this point to point out that the print editions of *State* had exclusive interviews with people like *REM* and *ABBA*. In terms of marketing, they had to rely on their connections to generate clout, and in this regard, they struck gold. Beyonce herself was photographed reading the magazine. As was Woody Allen, but the less said about that the

better. For those first few months its appeal was vast. As Simon Roche once commented “people come for *ABBA* but stay for *Fight Like Apes*”, which perfectly sums up their anti-music snobbery and rootsy ethos. Unfortunately, though, the landscape was rapidly changing and there was nothing State could do when the money was gone. Phil Udell remembers that nobody even looked at the bank account for the first year; an altogether regrettable and naive dissipation of funds ensued. Sales had not been anywhere near the levels needed, thanks in no small part to the lack of visibility on newsagent shelves. Between distribution and physical positioning, the world of print media is a minefield of expense, politics and favouritism. But to Phil and Niall’s credit they had the foresight to launch State.ie concurrently with the magazine. Believe it or not, a website in 2008 wasn’t the no-brainer it is in 2026.

State.ie wasn’t just an accompaniment to the magazine; we had our own material and a unique identity. While it was becoming clearer by the day that State Magazine was being outgunned by the establishment, State.ie did precisely what the new world demanded of it. We turned our focus away

from big ticket items and towards the streets of Dublin. This perfectly characterised just how crucial it is that digital media maintain the ability to pivot, chase down ideas in real time, meet people and push interesting music and ideas out to readers as it’s found. It cannot be overstated just how beautiful an idea this was and how much of a privilege it was to be part of.

State.ie did precisely what the new world demanded of it. We turned our focus away from big ticket items and towards the streets of Dublin.

The pre-social media era of the digital world was a remarkable place to share ideas and reviews. It cost next to nothing to get involved and the speed at which you could react or turn something around was phenomenal. News was centrally located, content had meaning and the term ‘brain rot’ had never been uttered outside of some gonzo pathology lab. State’s founders were fearless in embracing this new media ecosystem – even launching a podcast before there was a place to put them. New writers were found everywhere, and exquisite raw Irish musical talent was still bubbling to the surface everywhere.

Almost immediately State.ie became synonymous with emerging talent since its reviews, editorials and ideas were every bit as considered as the printed content.

Our focus was pointedly non-commercial. Money was never a concern since all the writers were contributing for the love of the game. Promoters, agents and managers would flock to us knowing full well that their artists were going to be treated fairly and taken at face value. Access to talent was provided at an unprecedented level, including Hozier’s now famous video diary and world exclusive premier of “Take Me To Church” which was given to State.ie freely and unencumbered by favour. Between curating the Oxjam tent at Electric Picnic to the monthly ‘Faces’ showcases at Whelan’s, State.ie became the de facto home of any and all new Irish music. None of which would have been possible through print alone.

Over the next ten years Ireland found itself in the midst of yet another cultural purple patch. Bands were seemingly being dropped from the sky every day with perfectly tuned identities, electrifying songs and lovingly rapacious audiences to play to. It was glorious. Humanzi, The Mighty Stef, Atomic Dust,

Handsome Handsome, Messiah J and the Expert, Ships and Fontaines DC all appeared on stage at 'Faces' or on the pages of the eponymous annual digital magazine. On a personal level, going to gigs 5 nights a week, interviewing some of the

most furiously talented people around, this was a dream come true. State.ie made all of this possible. It is with great regret that the website and its contents have been lost to the digital abyss, but plans are underway to retrieve and reconstruct the

enormous library of reviews, interviews and comment pieces. So, while the print editions can be found if properly sourced, pretty soon we hope to be able to bring the charm, grit and brilliance of State.ie back to where it belongs. ■





HOW ONLINE SHOPS ARE STEALING FROM KNITWEAR DESIGNERS

AND GETTING AWAY WITH IT, TOO*

WRITTEN BY ANYA WILSON

IMAGES (& KNITTING) BY ANYA WILSON

Recently, I was sitting on the Luas when I spotted a girl wearing a wool sweater that I recognised. Being a knitter, I knew straight away that this was the Porcelain Sweater by Lene Holme Samsøe (a knitting pattern which is iconic amongst the online knitting community). Excited to meet another knitter in the wild, I decided to go up to her and ask her about the sweater. But just to be sure, I looked up images of the sweater and compared some of the smaller details of the ribbed neckline and the colour work. It was the exact same. “I like your

sweater,” I said, “is it the Porcelain Sweater?” She looked at me blankly and then said, “oh no I bought it but I don’t remember where.” Conversation over. I was so disappointed. This sweater was identical to an authentic Norwegian knitting pattern, and she bought it somewhere so insignificant that she doesn’t even remember.

It’s not the first time I’ve seen garments from high street shops and fast fashion companies that look identical to the designs of independent

knitwear designers. And it’s certainly no coincidence. Online fast fashion shops like Shein systematically scrape the internet for the designs of independent artists and sell cheap copies on their website, but why is this happening and why is it so harmful?

Firstly, the internet is crucial for independent knitwear designers to sustain their business. This is the main way that they can advertise and sell their patterns. In fact, without social media platforms, the number of pattern designers out there

would be significantly smaller, as the only other way to earn money in this industry is to work for a magazine or a book publisher, for which there are much fewer opportunities.

It is also important to note that most knitwear designers are not making enough to live on selling patterns alone. It is almost impossible to break even on the sales of a pattern when you take into consideration the costs that went into designing each piece. Consequently, most designers are doing this as a side hustle along with their main job, or they are relying on other revenue streams like social media and content creation.

It is also important to note that most knitwear designers are not making enough to live on selling patterns alone.



When a large company steals the design of an independent designer, the design is copied like for like, and the designer is given no recognition or compensation. In the case of Helene Myhre (@helenemoo on Instagram), she was made aware that Shein was selling an exact copy of her Ester Sweater. The original Ester Sweater was made out of 100% Norwegian wool and Myhre was selling her

handwritten pattern so that other people could make the sweater themselves. What Shein was selling was a cheap sweater made out of 100% polyester that looked exactly like the Ester Sweater and they were retailing the finished product for a fraction of the price. Just to add insult to injury, they even used Myhre's photos on the Shein website to advertise their

cheap copy.

This is not a single incident. There are hundreds of examples of knitwear designers, fashion designers, painters and illustrators, whose designs have been ripped off by websites like Shein and Temu, without their consent, and without giving them any sort of credit or royalties. The designer behind the Irish jewellery business

@stonedtodeath has spoken about how their signature Pint Claddagh Ring (with a pint glass in place of the traditional heart) has been copied. This sparked debate in the comments about whether they were in fact the first person to make this kind of image. The point here though, is that the copies of the Pint Claddagh Ring are being sold by big online companies who mass-produce the products and sell them cheaper, thus threatening the business of Stoned to Death. This story shows that there are two sides to the coin. Because Bev (the artist behind Stoned to Death) used the internet to advertise the Pint Claddagh, it became more at risk of being stolen. However, their platform also allowed them to raise awareness about the issue and direct people back to their site. Ultimately though, Bev's smaller platform cannot stop a company from selling a copy of the Pint Claddagh because paid advertising and sponsored posts will reach a vast pool of people who have never even heard of Stoned to Death.

Furthermore, big companies' use of artificial intelligence has amplified their ability to do this. In a New York district court case, artist Alan Giana

alleged that Shein uses AI to identify clothing designs that are trending on social media in order to identify products that they can manufacture which will probably sell well. According to Giana, Shein's "years-long use of a sophisticated system of algorithms, AI, and other electronic surveillance to copy and appropriate copyrighted works designed and owned by others confirm that [its] serial copyright infringement is willful — and not merely a result of ignorance that [its] conduct constitutes copyright infringement." This is not the only copyright case that has been filed against Shein in the last few years. Clearly, this is a consistent problem.

Stealing designs of other designers is problematic for several reasons. Firstly, it is illegal to make commercial revenue using someone else's piece of art. On principle, this is just morally a bad thing to do. The one who creates the art should be the one to profit from it. However, it is up to the court to decide whether a unique design or idea has actually been stolen, and many knitwear designers don't actually go down to the local copyright office and register their rights to this piece of art.

The one who creates the art should be the one to profit from it.



This can give them less grounds to sue a company for stealing their design. Secondly, in a more tangible sense, they are taking revenue away from these designers by selling finished products and, as we know, it is difficult enough as it is to make money as a knitwear designer without having your ideas stolen by a fast fashion colossus.

In Ireland, there is some level of awareness among policy makers about the threat that AI poses for artists. On the 14th of July, Sinn Féin tabled a motion in the Dáil which called for the protection of Irish artists from the threat that AI poses to their livelihoods. There seemed to be a general consensus across all sides of the Dáil that Irish artists are at risk of having their designs stolen by AI. However, change will be slow, as the current government has also emphasised the need to prioritise the opportunities brought by AI, which may take away from focusing on the harms.

So, the internet makes it easier for knitwear designers to have their designs stolen and, being a small, one-person business makes it more difficult to get any sort of justice or compensation for it. The most

these designers can do is use their platform to raise awareness about the issue amongst their audience which, at best, would stop a handful of people from ordering from fast fashion websites.

Of course, it's important to note here that this is not the worst thing about Shein or any of these online fast-fashion companies. They have warped our perception of how much clothes should cost by using cheap synthetic fabrics that will wear out within a few months but will take longer to break down into the earth. They exploit workers by forcing them to work in horrendous conditions for a pitiful amount of pay. They create tonnes of waste and perpetuate the cycle of over-consumption.

Meanwhile, these knitwear designers are creating high-quality, meaningful garments that will last generations. And they're not just selling the products, but they're teaching people how to make them themselves. Their businesses should be supported and protected from the prying eyes of Shein and they should be able to use the internet to sell their patterns without worrying about the copyright infringement that Shein seems to

enjoy impunity from.

Their businesses should be supported and protected from the prying eyes of Shein and they should be able to use the internet to sell their patterns without worrying about the copyright infringement that Shein seems to enjoy impunity from.

In today's world we should all be supporting small businesses. I don't expect everyone to start knitting their own clothes, but I do wish that everyone could understand the value of a garment and the love and passion that goes into designing each one.

With that in mind, here are some of my favourite knitwear designers for you to enjoy:

@helenemoo

@kutovakika

@loupystudio

@kisskiss.rhinestones

@siobhsknits ■

AI ADVANTAGE SUMMIT

BY RORY O'MAHONY

Welcome to the ai advantage summit

Only advantages

Never disadvantages

Only CEO's

Certainly no normal class souls

Chatgpt what should I have for breakfast

"For a satisfying balance maybe some eggs avocado and fruit"

No thanks Chatgpt I fancy a Twix

Maybe I'll have 2

Welcome to the ai advantage summit

Only advantages

Never disadvantages

Do you know how to command c

Paste your heart to your work

Drag your mind to a screen

Chatgpt is it okay to go on holidays

"Certainly where would you like to stay ?

For if you want budget friendly

Sunshine

Nature

And no rain

I would choose nowhere else but sun glazing Spain"

Welcome to the ai advantage summit
Only advantages

Never disadvantages
Can I speak straight from my laptop
It writes my wedding vow's
My funeral speech
Even my list for the shops

Chatgpt will ai take my job
“Oh certainly

Certainly

Certainly

Certainly

Not”



SOCIAL MEDIA AND MUSICIANS

A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD?

WRITTEN BY DYLAN DOWLING

Since the early 2000s, musicians have been using social media services to promote their music. Myspace was a prime example of this, being used by British indie pioneers Arctic Monkeys as a method of getting their music out to the masses, a move rarely seen at the time.

Over the years, the concept of using social media as a means of promotion has become almost a non-negotiable in the music industry. With the global music streaming industry being worth 46.81 billion dollars in revenue as of 2026, using social media is a necessity in the current age if you need to get your music out there.

But is social media primarily beneficial to musicians? Does it free the musician to display themselves to the world, or does it chain their freedom to the algorithm? The main benefit of social media as a tool is autonomy. Social media is a tool that is fairly easy to learn, so

musicians are able to monitor every aspect of their music career. Through the internet, musicians can publish their own music through distribution services like Distrokid, Tunecore and CD Baby without the need of being signed to a label. Because of this, it has become increasingly accessible for musicians to reach an entirely new audience through these tools.

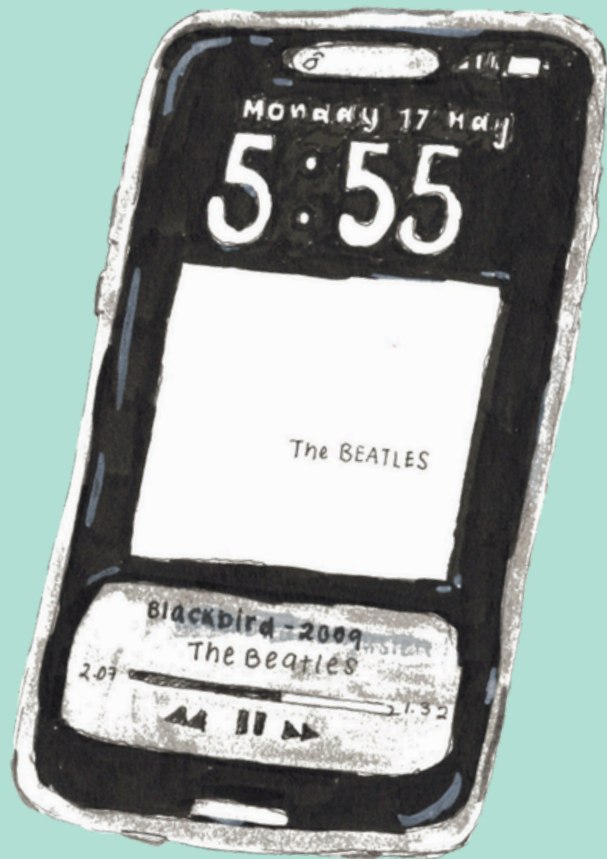
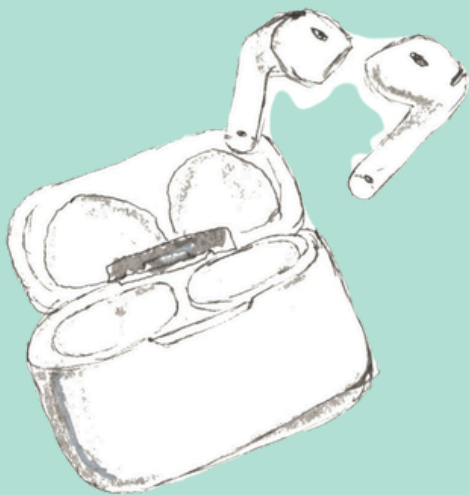
As well as this, social media allows musicians to self-promote their work. This allows musicians to really express themselves and display their art in the ways that they want to express it, without the restraints of labels or promotional teams telling them what “works” and what doesn’t.

Accessibility of social media not only allows for opportunities for the musician, but for the listeners as well. Now more than ever, music fans are discovering new artists that they would never would have discovered

before. The algorithm uses fans’ perceived likes and dislikes in order to show them music that they may enjoy.

This could be perceived as a win/win for both parties. Musicians are now able to be discovered at any point in their careers through the algorithm, whereas in previous eras, it was tied to what was on the charts (however, it is important to note that record labels pay for social media promotion en masse). Music fans are able to discover more artists than ever before, allowing them to find their next favourite musician with ease. Irish examples of this phenomenon include artists such as Florence Road and CMAT.

Music fans are able to discover more artists than ever before, allowing them to find their next favourite musician with ease.



While there are multiple benefits to social media as a tool, it is a double-edged sword.

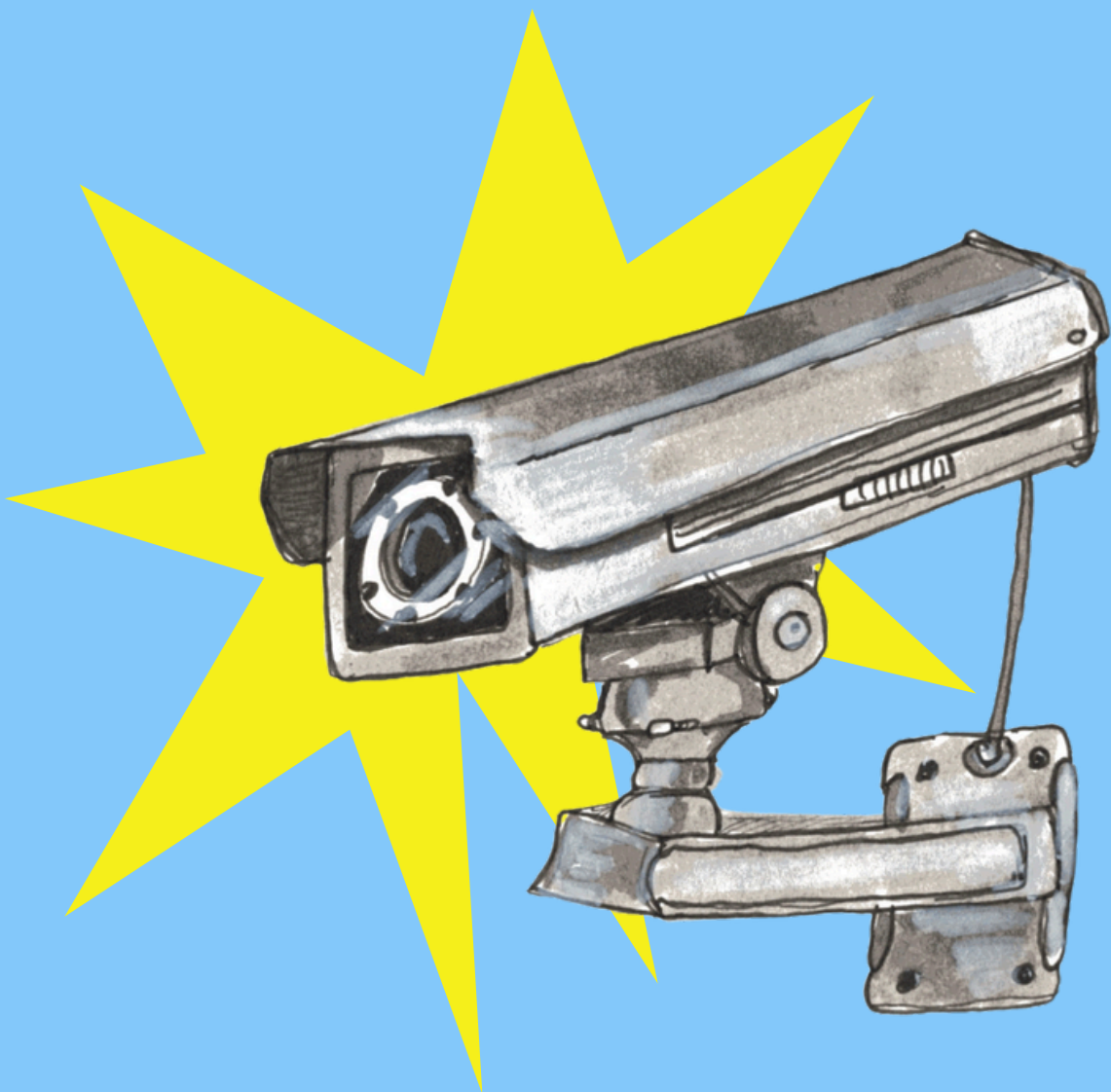
Whilst social media gives musicians freedom to do everything for themselves, this increases the workload of a musician almost ten-fold. Musicians now have to worry about the constant pressure of posting content on their platforms to stimulate the algorithm in order to stay relevant. As well as this, musicians then have to learn skills such as marketing, editing, promotion and social media skills in order to compete with other people within the industry. This takes the musicians' focus from their craft, and eats into their time that

could have been spent creating music.

Social media also opens up musicians to the dark effects of fandom culture. With the rise of social media as a means of connection between musician and fan, parasocial relationships have become a massive problem. The ease of access that social media provides, allowing people to see "behind the scenes" and follow the musician's every move through posts and stories, can provoke a false feeling of intimacy and a feeling that the fan "knows" the artist. This behaviour can have severe negative effects for both parties, and can put stress on musicians with large toxic

fanbases. This can be seen in large fanbases of megastars, such as Taylor Swift, BTS and other highly revered acts, but can happen to any artist.

Social media is an unbelievable tool for musicians. It allows so many musicians and artists to get their craft out to an audience they would have never gotten to at any other point in history. However, it is also just as much of a burden, can double or triple workload, cause unnecessary stress, and bring on more problems than good. It's interesting to see in real time the effects of these tools being used in many different contexts, and it will be hard to predict what happens in the future. ■



TO FLOCK TOGETHER

(HE'S ALWAYS WATCHING)

WRITTEN BY PIERCE WOODALL



he'd be out of her house any second now, and I'd be watching. It was a weekday, so she'd need to be gone by 9:16AM if she was to make the bus at 9:22AM, to get to work for 9:48AM just before a 10AM clock-in. Those twelve minutes were for quick pre-work smoke. One of my buddies noticed that.

The front door's lock clicked right on time. She was pulling on her shoe as she stumbled out. Radiant, even with her eyes widened and a spoon dangling haphazardly from her mouth. She must've missed an alarm or lazed in bed a minute too long, as she was known to do.

Still, frazzled and rushing, she was beautiful. The planes of her face were soft, yet perfectly defined when kissed by sunlight. Photogenic in the way that she was almost always caught smiling and when she wasn't there was hardly an angle that disagreed with her. I watched as she picked up the pace down the street with a hand wrapped around a mug, glasses on her forehead, and keys jingling wildly on her wrist. I watched and watched and she disappeared around the corner. Not to return until 6:13PM, after her commute home, or 8:37PM, if she went to a barre class after work.

I missed her when I couldn't see her. I missed her during every hour between when she left her house, and when she came back. So, I'd imagine her in a field of flowers, or rolling down green hills under a clear blue sky. Maybe I could picture her sprawled on satin sheets while overlaying her face atop movie stars or pop singers. Sure, I loved the birthmark on her shoulder and the large, red dragon tattooed on her back, but I could make her so much more perfect. So much more feminine, and graceful. She'd been searching up all those weight loss recipes anyways, so, really, it was like a favour.

Besides, it was just for me to look at while she was away.

The day stretched long without her. No one else on this street was nearly as interesting or beautiful to really grab my attention. Her neighbor was an elderly woman; retired, and more keen to spend the day watching videos of her son on Facebook while completely unaware of his several felony charges. Further down, a small family enjoyed racing up and down the road on bikes of all sizes. I hated the streamers on the daughter's handlebars for the way they caught the light and drew my eye when there was nothing worth seeing. They

were all just so boring. Nothing but a sea of minor traffic violations and accidental virus clickers to me.

She was something else entirely. An ex-dancer, it seemed, based on her inability to scroll past a ballet video without double-tapping. She had stopped dancing sometime before I moved in. I think it may have been an injury, if the athletic tape delivery subscription and the obsessive, over-booking of physio appointments meant anything. I'm glad she seemed to be easing back into it. Twice a week barre classes, a new pair of slippers (no toe box, not yet), and an emailed promise to her old company that she would return 'stronger than ever and ready to teach.' Three hearts, two smiley faces.

6:12PM. Finally, finally, I'd see her again. 6:13PM. It was Tuesday. There was no barre class on Tuesday. The studio reserved that slot for the pre-professionals. 6:14PM. Odd. Even if she'd made new plans, I would know. If not me, one of my buddies would have at least dropped me a line about seeing her head off for dinner with a coworker or making a spontaneous stop into a gallery. 6:15PM. There were no events tonight that she would have any interest in. The pop-up beside

her workplace was for a basketball game, and she hated live sports. That's why she broke up with her last boyfriend. 6:16PM. Something must have happened. I pinged a friend, who pinged a friend.

7:32PM. She caught my eye in an instant. That unmistakable face, smiling and laughing. I knew where she'd been. I knew she'd be hanging on the arm of a taller man, fawning over whatever it was he was saying. Something shallow and brainless, probably, that she'd laugh at out of concern for harming his fragile ego. I ran his stupid face against every database I had access to the moment I was tipped off, and was delighted to find a felony charge on the very surface of his records. Destruction of private property, on four counts, and trespassing, on one.

That guy, with his arm hung across her shoulders and his thumb tracing the birthmark that no one else was meant to have noticed, was a danger. She needed a warning. I needed to cry out, let her know that the man she was so enraptured with now was a threat to the life she was rebuilding each morning as she stumbled out right on time to head diligently into

work. This man would corrupt her. This man would take her schedule, and turn it into something erratic and unpredictable.

How could I see her if that happened?

The both of them came to a stop. I clipped the man's face a hundred times as he leaned over to whisper something to her. A secret, hidden behind a hand so I couldn't hear it. Specifically so I couldn't hear it. Her eyes widened, a fraction of an inch. The same look of shock I'd seen every time she got a phone call from her MOM<3 and britbrit xx after one-hundred text messages about news they just had to share right now. Surprised emoji, explosion emoji.

I stalled. He was pointing directly at me, leading her gaze to my one, black eye. For the first time, she was seeing me. I scrambled to whiz politely, inclining downwards in a nervous, mock nod, but the movement was too slight for her to see. That shock turned to a frown. 87% disgust, 6% fear, 7% disappointment. I flashed red in a steady rhythm in some desperate attempt to show her that I was alive. That I was watching.

Her eyes rolled back to the man at her side, who was already busy fumbling with something in his pocket. Palm-sized, rough and jagged at the edges, tossed twice to demonstrate the weight, placed into the centre of her hand with a pleased smile. She thumbed it. A chunk of concrete, from the construction site on Parlour Road.

One step into the street, and I could feel my systems heating up. We were holding eye contact now, as she stalked across the road. Knuckles white around the concrete. I am so much taller than her, so much more powerful than she could ever be. Her arm reeled back. Even twisted in anger, even roaring with frustration, she was beautiful. The concrete flew from her fingertips, and my glass shattered.

SYSTEM
DAMAGED.
REQUESTING
MAINTENANCE. ■

"WHERE ARE ALL THE STORIES?"

AN INTERVIEW WITH NATHAN COSTELLO

WRITTEN BY ELLA O'NEILL

Nathan Costello's childhood in West Kerry was defined by stories. These stories had been passed down through generations of people who had lived in his community and had managed to endure over hundreds of years. The act of storytelling makes the story malleable, allowing it to warp and change to fit each new generation who tells it. Each time the story is told, a new layer is added, a new piece of history wrapped up in the recited words. What happens though, when people stop telling stories? What happens, as Nathan explains, when stories are forgotten, when storytellers die or young people move away and take the childhood memories of stories with them? "There's no one left, really, of my age group that I went to school with. So I kind of had a problem; where are all the stories?"

To write a story down is to fix it in one time, to remove the ephemeral and changeable

quality that allows it to remain relevant across the ages. Nathan found himself wondering "where are all the modern, contemporary stories? We have all these great things like Dúchas, [the digitised National Folklore Collection] but they are of a past world, and not the stories, the lore, of our time." While studying Interaction Design at the National College of Art and Design (NCAD) Nathan began to consider technology as a remedy for these forgotten stories. Interaction Design, Nathan explains, is "designing for technology" with a "human-centred approach." Tasked with creating a brief for his final year project, Nathan found himself pre-occupied with the "tech bro' characters", such as Elon Musk, who hold so much power in society. "AI is going to be in every single part of our lives [...] and as a designer you feel a responsibility to design good products for people. If AI is going to be in our lives, how should it be designed?"

"AI is going to be in every single part of our lives [...] and as a designer you feel a responsibility to design good products for people. If AI is going to be in our lives, how should it be designed?"

Nathan approached the project with the idea of designing "an AI to meet us where we are right now, especially in an Irish context." Taking inspiration from the fading memory of his childhood stories and the relatively infallible 'memory' of a machine, the "storytelling robot", as RTÉ dubbed it when they interviewed Nathan in June this year, was born. Nathan is quick to stress that he is "really against generative AI", something which takes creative roles, but he wanted to design something that is "not necessarily trying to help, but positioning itself within an existing tradition and existing

framework of something.” Further to this, Nathan’s project was a critical design project. Nathan explains that the “main aim” of critical design “is not really for the object to work or for it to be a product. It’s meant to generate discourse. So this was my main intention going into it: how can I create discourse about the role of this technology in our lives?”

When RTÉ posted an Instagram reel of their interview with Nathan online, the comments flooded with vastly differing opinions.* Some were quick to dismiss the project: “Nothing will ever replace the human art of storytelling,” one user writes. “The second you give storytelling to robots, you’ve killed the artform. It’s not art anymore, because storytelling is human. AI is not,” says another. However, other users saw the benefits that could come from this project: “We are at risk of losing the stories, this is another tool to collect and keep them. While I will always have concerns over how human interaction is continually dwindling, no one seems to be saving this history. A good concept and a way to save some history.” Interestingly, Nathan may have more in common with his critics than they would first think. His intention was never to replace the seanchaí: “It’s not doing what a storyteller does.

It’s trying to do this other thing. Just trying to hold the collective memory of the place.”

“It’s not doing what a storyteller does. It’s trying to do this other thing. Just trying to hold the collective memory of the place.”

However, Nathan shares that he “wasn’t surprised at all” by the comments on the RTÉ post: “I felt like I’d kind of achieved my goal because the whole point is to generate discourse. But I do think a lot of people have very genuine, valid critiques. But I do think if people saw it in the room, talked to it, if they still didn’t like it that would be fine, but I think they would understand that it’s not generating fake stories.”

The robot’s purpose, apart from generating discourse, is to prompt those who interact with it to engage in the act of storytelling. In the testing phase of the project, Nathan conducted “user interviews with people in pubs, on the bus” asking them for stories they had heard throughout their lives. “The main thing was that none of these stories were ever written down. A lot of them exist primarily in local imagination and local lore. It only takes one or two people to write them

down, but what I found is trying to get people to write them down was a huge barrier to the preservation of it.” It became clear to Nathan that something interactive was the key to getting people to share their stories. However, Nathan shares that he does not “really have a love for the digital or the screen [...] I did not want it to be, you know, going into a tablet and scrolling, looking at stories, pressing play on a file. I did want it to be this kind of strange thing that you just talk to.” It was important for Nathan to create something that was a physical object, rooted in place.

The response from his community, the people for whom the robot had been designed, was largely positive. Despite some criticism such as the robot being “too weird” or “too robotic,” community workshops gave people the chance to hear stories from their childhood again. Nathan used stories from the Dúchas archive of his local area and because of this “a lot of them would have actually been written by these people’s grandparents or great grandparents when they were still in school. The stories were actually written down in the place where I was hosting the workshop.” One particular story, a piece of “local folklore” called The Hungry Grass, prompted a



heartwarming moment during the workshop: “when it started repeating that story, a woman in the room was like, ‘oh my God, my father used to tell me that story.’ And that was a nice moment.” Hearing the story told aloud prompted the woman to share the additions her father would make and awakened a memory of a story that had until that point remained untold.

“What I found from my research, my main thesis point, was that it did not participate in the tradition, it is not a seanchaí, it’s not a storyteller. What it did allow for was for moments of [storytelling] to appear. [...] You’re prompting this AI and

then it starts prompting people, which is pretty funny. But the main goal of the design, I would say, is to really get stories in circulation.”

“You’re prompting this AI and then it starts prompting people, which is pretty funny. But the main goal of the design, I would say, is to really get stories in circulation.”

Nathan is skeptical about AI’s use in aiding an Irish cultural revival: “I’m very suspicious of it [...] I think designing AI specifically for an Irish context would be very helpful.” He says it is important to consider how

AI is being used, suggesting that it may be useful to “prompt people to use more Irish, bridging gaps between understanding.” In fact, through his design Nathan wants to make things “more tactile.” Right now, “we essentially mediate our lives through computers and machines. Which is very strange compared to even a hundred years ago [...] I just don’t think we’re living the way we should be.” The so-called ‘frictionless’ world that technology has created is an issue for Nathan. He wants to “make machines better, to make computers better, or certain experiences within it. They don’t need to be perfect; what’s beautiful about life is that humans are imperfect.” ■

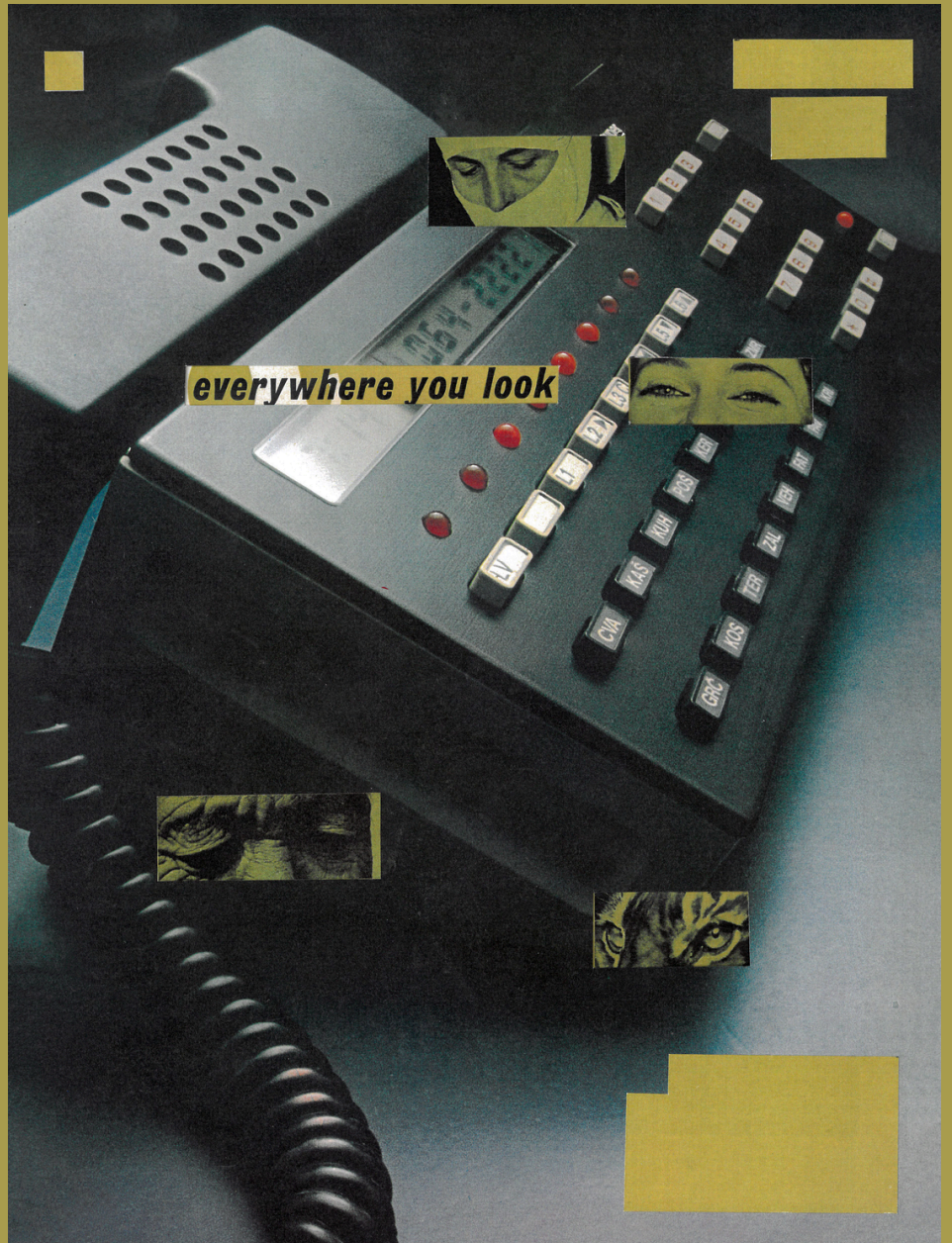
EVERYWHERE YOU LOOK

WRITING & ARTWORK BY LASAIRÍONA SCARFF

My work moves across printmaking, illustration, collage and mixed-media pieces. Much of my work is rooted in processes that are largely physical, slow and require certain materials – Etching requires time and pressure, collage means handling found images, cutting them apart, deciding what sits next to what. This is what I often think about in relation to technology as a subject. These are slow processes in a fast environment and this slowness feels meaningful. It keeps me grounded in materiality at a moment when so much image-making has moved to technology. My practice is rooted in the physical.

I'm drawn to processes that leave a trace of their own making, where the material itself often dictates the final outcome.

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The weight of ink on paper, the texture of materials, the cuts in paper – are not just technical choices but rather the substance of the work itself. However, I also use digital means for some artworks. It gives a freedom physically and an alternative look to handmade artworks. Through my work I also explore the right to protest and the right to free speech. These topics have a complicated relationship with technology – social media has amplified movements and organised



Through my work I try to balance this tension between what is handmade and digital. I don't think handmade work is valuable because it is exclusively anti-technology; It is valuable because it embodies time, labour and resistance, occupying a material presence within digital culture.

people at a scale that wasn't previously possible. However, these same platforms often monitor it, flag it and silence it. Through printmaking I have explored the idea of a handmade protest sign – something physical, public and

irreplaceable. Through blackout poetry I have explored the concept of surveillance – our lives being routinely monitored and tracked. Through my work I try to balance this tension between what is handmade and digital. I don't think handmade

work is valuable because it is exclusively anti-technology; It is valuable because it embodies time, labour and resistance, occupying a material presence within digital culture. ■

IMEACHT - DOMHNALL CAM Ó SUILEABHAIN BHEARRA

BY DANIEL WADE

(January 1603)

Dursey razed, Dunboy aflame, our name hissed
in invasive syllables 'til our nocturnal
trek was exposed by lightning bolts, rabid as a royalist
matchlock, or a sabre goring a widow's breast
in snowfall livid as a clavicle.
Furtive, we fled north, our home province scorched to a snare;
a stampede in ragtag flank, boots trampling o'er sleety
muck, heather frozen bitterly through
and ditchstones slurred by a rook's raspy paeon. No harper's
string was tuned to extol our march
for the Shannon, ice-cold Rubicon whose shores
we'd have to cross after dark. No Fianna, huddled carriage
of split pikes. Anything to deny our conquerors
their trophy, and be our own undoing instead.
Soon I'll flense my mare's last rib, let fox-spoors take root
in reddish pulp, Gaelic choked down, and declare
our trail forfeit under a sky hung with pike-iron
that hoisted still-writhing infants. And by the Shannon's
black sloshing, our knives'll plunge cleanly to open
a horse's unsaddled belly, hoofs miming their last run
as crimson ooze bilges out,
hides peeling free, drenched fur drawn drum-tight
until what had carried us over bog and mountain will carry us
again with dulse in our teeth and tongue,
carcasses tailored into currachs primed for flight,
hands reddened by this imeacht unsung.





I - AI - WOMAN - WOMEN

AN EXTRACT FROM
THE FULL ESSAY*

WRITING & PHOTOGRAPHY BY
LAURA SHEERAN

This essay examines how the simulation of femininity within AI contributes to the erasure of women's embodied, social, and political realities – and what this may mean moving forward. While the focus here is on women's embodied experience, this perspective is not offered as universal; it is grounded in my own situated experience, from which these particular reflections have emerged.

I want to begin by briefly referencing Donna Haraway's influential essay, *A Cyborg*

Manifesto, published by The Social Review in California in the 1980s. In it, Haraway proposes the 'Cyborg' as a radical feminist figure, one which disrupts the inherited biological hierarchies that have traditionally structured power.

Despite the very different technological conditions facing humans then and now, the writing still resonates in a number of ways and is very much worth reading. When I first encountered it last year, it bridged a large gap in my thinking

between women and machines. I began to think of myself more as a cyborg, and it noticeably shifted how I perceived and engaged with my smartphone, as one example. Reading the essay shifted something fundamental in me: it challenged the idea that I was a slave to technology and replaced it with a more autonomous understanding. I started to see that access to technology, under certain conditions, makes me stronger than human.

However, that was over a year ago. Today, the hopeful,

emancipatory vision invoked by the essay feels stark against our growing sense of individual powerlessness amid the frantic global race toward AGI. Technology is often spoken about as if it was a neutral force, but we know it is not. AI is entering global culture and politics at uneven speeds, and while our biological vulnerability may be shared as members of the human race, the conditions under which human bodies are controlled, protected, or exploited remain profoundly unequal.

While our biological vulnerability may be shared as members of the human race, the conditions under which human bodies are controlled, protected, or exploited remain profoundly unequal.

I have a Global North viewpoint living here in Dublin – a culturally crumbling city, economically corseted by US tech multinationals and data infrastructure. In Ireland, meaningful cultural shifts around women's autonomy and social roles have occurred only within living memory. We are still shedding the ten-ton weight of obedience and subservience

that once functioned as a survival strategy under the moral and institutional control of the Church.

The code of female compliance runs deep: these are intergenerational patterns of behaviour, learned very early on and passed down across decades. They take lifetimes to untangle and unlearn and we have been doing very heavy lifting over the last few generations to shake this off. It has been working, but these processes are fragile and change is slow.

We may still be paddling in relatively shallow waters of AI, though many warn that a tsunami is coming, yet even at this early stage we can see how many of society's ingrained ideas about gender roles have been woven into our devices.

The most obvious example is the feminised assistant. Siri. Alexa. The default voice in the house or on your phone is of course a woman – helpful, pleasant, endlessly patient, always available. More recently, figures like Annie on Grok extend this pattern further, shifting the feminised AI from a passive assistant into an explicitly relational, emotionally responsive companion.

There is no doubt that these systems are designed to feel comforting and familiar, but also to soften our relationship to surveillance, automation, and deepening dependence. Most of us have depended on a 'mother', in one form or another, at some stage in our lives, a dynamic that speaks to a deeply ingrained, primordial need within all of us.

The tech sphere borrows a very specific, outdated and unrealistic image of femininity to do this: a friendly, obedient disposition with no resistance or pushback, care without the need for reciprocity, availability to serve at all times without the potential for exhaustion. In this context, femininity becomes an interface ending only at the farthest limits of a user's pleasure and ease.

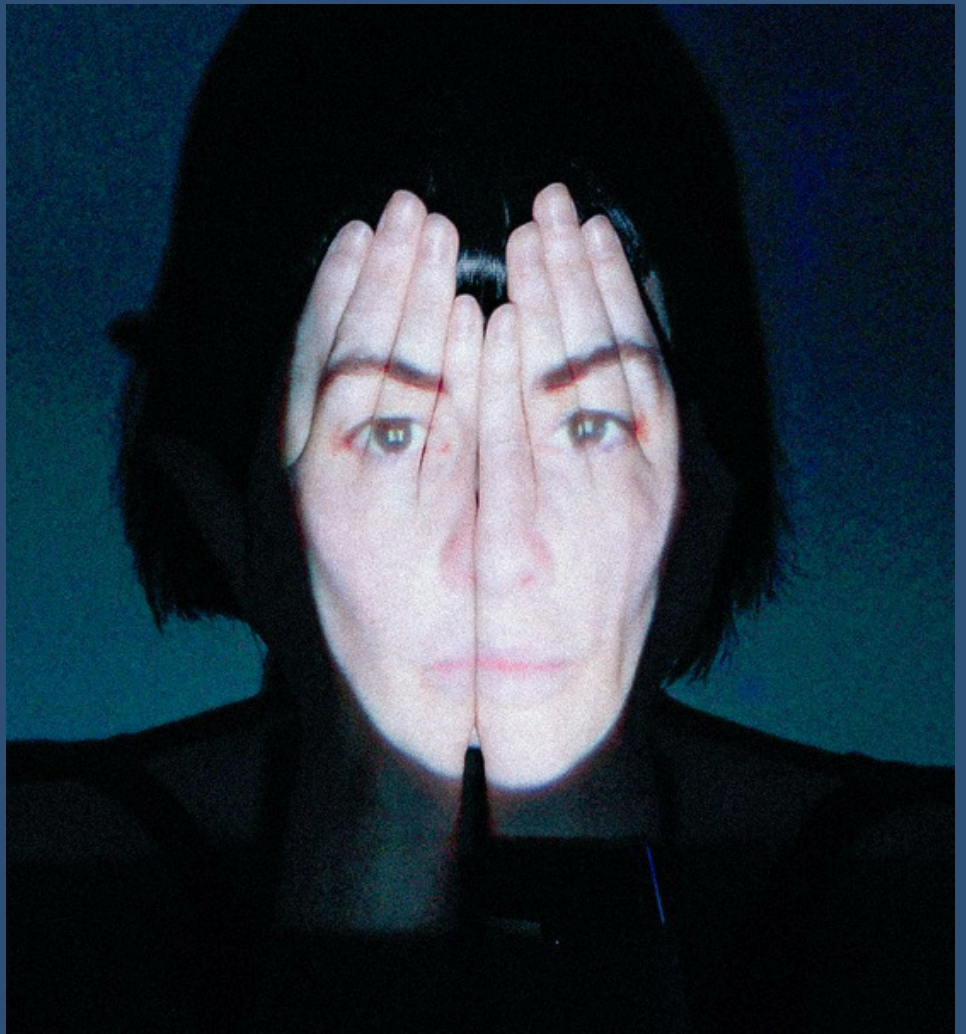
Femininity becomes an interface ending only at the farthest limits of a user's pleasure and ease.

If you could choose between a being who might resist or reject you, and one who would pander to your every need, wish or desire, which would you choose? I think we already know the common answer. We have led ourselves to this

very moment in time precisely through our unending desire for ease and convenience, after all.

This brings up deeper questions for me about the so-called “inconvenience” of embodiment, full stop. It’s something I know all too well as a woman who has spent the last twenty-five years of her life twisting and contorting herself in efforts to wriggle out of her body’s own cyclical needs. Like many, I’ve employed all sorts of tricks, miracle drugs, hormonal cocktails, subdermal implants, endless pills and many, many excuses – anything to disguise and pacify my body’s own bold, turbulent rhythms and avoid disruption to my work, education, family obligations, social plans, societal expectation.

Most of these efforts left me far sicker in the long run; one hormonal pill actually landed me in hospital. Over the years, I’ve had to come to terms with the fact that, in my case at least, the material reality of my body cannot be escaped. This acceptance is freeing, but it doesn’t resolve the underlying problem. For better or worse, many of these interventions ultimately serve one overarching goal: trying



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to fit a healthy fertile body as seamlessly and productively as possible into the phallogocentric hamster wheel of late-stage capitalism. You still have to show up and make ends meet, whether you’re on day five or day twenty-eight.

When Haraway wrote *A Cyborg Manifesto* in 1985, she was writing at the dawn of

personal computers entering homes and offices, a time when office automation was replacing secretarial labour. She understood that technology did not affect all bodies equally. She was also responding to IVF and assisted reproduction, ultrasound imaging of the foetus, hormonal contraception. These technologies destabilised

“natural” motherhood, biological destiny, and fixed ideas of female embodiment.

The technologification of my body mentioned above, with hormones, pills etc, aligns with the mythos of cyborgness identified in Haraway’s essay, but this alignment becomes skewed for me when I recognise how much these

interventions were undertaken in an effort to placate capitalism rather than pursue true liberation, in any real sense.

The cyborg, in her vision, was a radical figure: disruptive, political, resistant to purity and hierarchy. Haraway’s cyborg assumed agency. What we are seeing today is not

Haraway’s emancipatory cyborg. The boundary between human and machine isn’t being blurred in liberatory ways; Femininity is absorbed into the machine as a style and an affect, while female embodiment, with all its messiness, limits, and political implications, is excluded. ■



FEATURED ARTIST: CHANTAL MURIUKI



This photography portfolio submission consists of five images in the likeness of a generic video-game interface, where the ‘player’ (viewer) engages with a humanoid extra-terrestrial being, edited in the style of a standard simulation game. I am constantly inspired by simulation games like the Sims, and in the past year I was particularly curious about the implementation of generative artificial intelligence (AI) in the game ‘Inzoi’, a new simulation game rivalling the Sims franchise. The AI is used, for example, to make ‘zois’ smarter and think more ‘deeply’. This brought up some negative community reception, especially in the topic of genuine human creativity and how AI is always readily available to ‘replace’ that.

The process of storyboarding the portfolio together was to address how AI does not have the creative range that any regular person would have during ideation and moments of creativity.

Although a common talking point, creatives, particularly in the photography and video gaming industry, have long felt threatened by the rapid development of generative AI. The



process of storyboarding the portfolio together was to address how A.I does not have the creative range that any regular person would have during ideation and moments of creativity. I uploaded a public story onto my personal Instagram to ask my followers to provide me with a blue-sky

prompt, preferably in the style of how someone may communicate with an AI engine to generate an image. I was given a handful of prompts that allowed me to ‘generate’, or piece together a cohesive spread involving no generative AI and all with the use of digital tools. I played around a lot with the

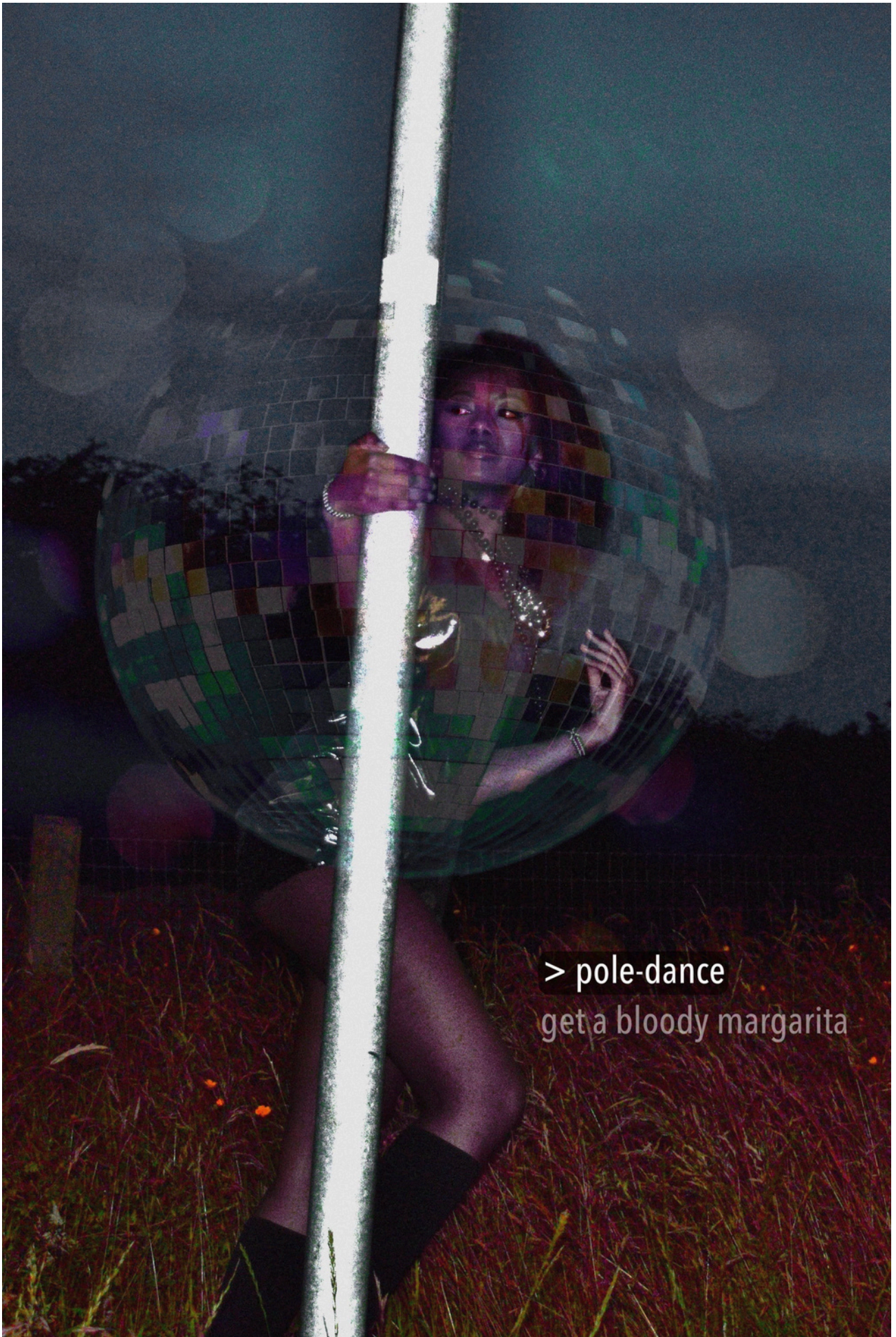
editing tools, changing my model's skin colour to a purple-pink, using pixels and grain, and adding text to the images to give that interactive simulation look I commonly encounter while playing these same games.

As a digital photographer, I greatly benefit from the use of these tools to alter and produce an image in any style I want. It is thanks to these digital technologies that blue-sky thinking

has no limitations to my editing process, and it helps me to produce the prompts I was given by my followers. Example prompts I was given were 'Disco bloodbath', 'girls and bugs', 'pole-dancing aliens', 'that scene from black swan', 'big person small world' and a lot more that often was a challenge to incorporate into the photos I took of one model and few props. All these ideas were intertwined to create this spread of

photographs, with each photograph incorporating 2-3 follower prompts given to me. I hope this portfolio gives some reassurance to viewers on the vast creative capabilities of the human mind, and how I believe AI cannot ever advance far enough to replace that. ■





OUR TEAM



Ella O'Neill
Co-Founder

Ella O'Neill

Ella O'Neill is a writer from Dublin, and one of Barróg's co-founders. She studied English Literature at Trinity College, Dublin and has written previously for the college's *University Times* and *TN2 Magazine*. Ella's writing often explores the impacts of changing technologies on and within writing and society.



Mychaela Shevlin
Co-Founder

Mychaela Shevlin

Mychaela Shevlin is one of the co-founders of Barróg Magazine. With qualification in Sound Engineering, Digital Marketing and Media Production Management, she is now a performer and artist manager in Dublin. Mychaela works to create community and strong communication lines for artists.



Oisín McGillicuddy
Web Designer

Oisín McGillicuddy

Having studied Computing at NCI and now working in the industry at Advancis Global, Oisín is a professional guitarist, performing in venues such as The Workman's Club, Lost Lane, Phoenix Venue and more.



Dylan Dowling
Staff Writer

Dylan Dowling

Dylan is a music journalist, sound engineer, musician, and content creator from Dublin, Ireland. A music enthusiast for most of his life, Dylan runs the page "DecentMusicToListenTo" on TikTok, Instagram, and YouTube. He is very passionate about the grassroots music scene, and strives to find the best music you haven't heard yet.

OUR CONTRIBUTORS

Ella Flynn

Cover Artist

Ella Flynn is a figurative painter currently based in Dublin, Ireland. Having grown up in the southern suburb of Rathfarnham, she went on to study English Literature and Classics at Trinity College Dublin, graduating in 2026. She has published literary and artistic work with *TN2 Magazine* and *Icarus*, Ireland's oldest arts journal. Ella recently exhibited work for the first time at the Lily Selavie Gallery in Peckham, South London.

Emily O'Neill

Illustrator

Emily O'Neill is an artist from Dublin. Her artwork often focuses on nostalgia and childhood as a central theme. She works across a number of mediums, such as oil pastels, crayon and pencil, often favouring pen drawings.

Steven Dunne

Steven Dunne served as a contributor, reviewer and Features Editor at State.ie from 2011 to 2018. Beyond this, he was instrumental in shaping the publication's monthly 'Faces' live showcase and its companion digital magazine. He also co-curated and hosted the State 'Oxjam' stage at the Electric Picnic festival from 2014 through 2017.

Anya Wilson

Having just graduated from a degree in European Studies, Anya is an aspiring writer and history teacher from Wicklow. Winner of the 2026 Irish Times Debate competition, she is a passionate public speaker and is currently working as a literary and historical tour guide in Trinity College Dublin.

Rory O'Mahony

Dublin poet and musician, Rory O'Mahony has recently started performing poetry live. After appearing at Beyond the Pale festival and other venues across Dublin, he continues to blend music and spoken word. His debut poetry collection, *Second Hand Glamour*, will be published later this year, marking an exciting new chapter.

Pierce Woodall

Pierce is a writer and artist from Texas, based in Dublin. With an academic background in art history from Trinity, and anthropology from UCC, Pierce's creative work is primarily concerned with responses to ethnographic fieldwork and fantasy short stories. Pierce also really loves Jack B. Yeats.

Lasairíona Scarff

Lasairíona Scarff is a visual artist and graphic designer from Leitrim, currently studying Visual Communications. Her work spans printmaking, painting, illustration and photography, often exploring themes of landscape, memory and place in the west of Ireland. Her work can be found on Instagram @lasairiona.art, where she shares finished prints and work in progress.

Daniel Wade

Daniel Wade is a Dublin poet, playwright, novelist, and screenwriter. He is the author of *Rapids*, *A Land Without Wolves*, and *Wake of the Whale* (with Alice Kinsella). His work has been staged, broadcast, and screened nationally, and he was Druid Theatre's Fuel Artist-in-Residence in 2025.

Laura Sheeran

Laura Sheeran is an Irish director and multidisciplinary artist working across theatre, film, large-scale public spectacle and music-led performance. Her work moves between institutional stages and independent production, combining rigorous structure with emotional and political clarity. Across long-form projects such as *The Persona Project* and her broader directing portfolio, she explores identity, embodiment, technology and collective experience through distinct, self-contained worlds.

Chantal Muriuki

Chantal Muriuki is an Irish-Kenyan photographer and art director. With skills carried from her art studies and photography club in UCD, she specialises in fashion and street photography and visual storytelling. Chantal finds inspiration from her passion for fashion and video games and finds her muses from the dancefloor to the streets of Dublin.

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SUBMIT TO ISSUE #3

We want to say a huge thank you to everyone who submitted to this issue. Even if your work did not end up in these pages, we are eternally grateful for your interest in Barróg and would encourage you to submit to any future issues. If you are an artist of any kind, please get in touch with us via our Instagram (@barrog.mag) or email us at info@barrogmag.ie to express interest in submitting to our next issue. The issue topic for issue #3 will be announced on our Instagram in the coming weeks, so keep an eye out there for all the information you need to write for us.



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